SYZYGY

Reflections on the Monastery of the Seven Rays

✠ Palamas

"'Syzygy' is the appropriate name for this text, yoking together as it does a wide variety of divergent streams. This is at one and the same time a deeply personal account of Tau Palamas' own spiritual journey and a rigorous examination of the Monastery of the Seven Rays' practice in relation to other currents and approaches. The journey is a sometimes dizzying one as Tau Palamas reels from one subject to the next, and from personal reflections to deeply theoretical speculations, the whole thing supplemented with a parade of stark and arresting images from his own paintbrush. This is a demanding text, perhaps at times too adventurous; one certainly not for the tyro. Its ultimate effect, however, is properly magical, and no one interested in contemporary magical praxis and Bertiaux's work will be left disappointed."

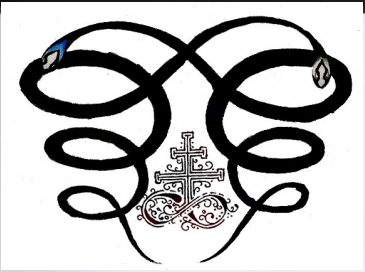
Abathur V°, Grand Master of the Friary/OSF

"A tour de force of creative synthesis, this extraordinary book sets out to fuse one of the most avant-garde branches of contemporary Western esotericism with the traditions of monastic prayer, contemplation and ritual, and carries out this more than usually demanding task with aplomb. Students of the mysteries weary of the rehashing of familiar teachings that dominates today's occult publishing scene will find it a welcome if dizzying breath of fresh air."

John Michael Greer, *Grand Archdruid of the Ancient Order of Druids in America*

"*Syzygy* is a fascinating exploration of the Voudon-Gnostic philosophy of Michael-Paul Bertiaux and the Monastery of the Seven Rays. The author, a Gnostic Bishop, takes us through his practice and experiences, telling us about meditation and prayer, Saints and spirits, magick and healing and even death and the dead. In the second half of the book, he offers practical ritual techniques to experience what he calls 'the Otherworld' for oneself. I suspect students of the Voudon-Gnostic coursework will find this text an invaluable companion for their studies."

Aaron Leitch, *author of* Secrets of the Magickal Grimoires *and* The Essential Enochian Grimoire.



✠ SYZYGY ✠

Reflections on the Monastery of the Seven Rays

✠ Palamas

Contents

Acknowledgements 9
Preface by Kyle Fite, SGM of the OTOA-LCN 15

Book 1: *Ora* 19
Introduction 21
Part I. A Monk in the World 27
1. Gyrovagi 29
2. Suscipe 35
3. Aequus Animus 41
4. Scala Dei 47
Part II. Monastic Life 53
1. Opus Dei 55
2. Lectio Divina 61
3. Obsculta 66
4. Conversatio Morum 73
Part III. The Dark Night of the Senses 77
1. Theoria Physike 79
2. Homila Pros Theon 85
3. Memento Mori 91
4. Silentium 99
Part IV. Transmutation 105
1. Ora et Labora 107
2. Curatio 113
3. Benedicamus 119
4. Caritas 125
Epilogue 131

Book 2: *Labora* 133
Introduction 135
Part I. Ritual Act of Oblation 139
Part II. Breviary 147
Part III. 16 Saints 165
Part IV. 16 Psalms 179

Acknowledgements

Throughout my journey within the Western Mystery Traditions, I have had the pleasure to learn from, work alongside and befriend Living Adepts and mystics. I am truly grateful for all of my teachers and guides, past and present. Among these, I would like to thank the following for their particular influence upon *Syzygy:*

I would like to thank my friend and the founding Bishop of the *Coptic Gnostic Church*, Tau Dositheos for his constant companionship and encouragement. Thanks to T Allen Greenfield for his living example of what it means to take upon oneself the mantle of a *Gerondas*. Thank you to Earl Keim and Kevin Davis—*Brothers in Arms* in labors Masonic and Gnostic. A heartfelt thank you to *Sovereign Grand Master*, Kyle Fite, for patiently reading the text and offering a Preface as well as being my mentor in the Orders. Thank you to Chic and Tabatha Cicero for introducing me to the Mysteries a decade ago and encouraging me to discover the Lux Occulta. Thank you to ArchBishop John Gilbert and his wife, ✠Charlene Mullen, for the blessing of Ordination and the hours of pastoral formation and direction. Thank you to Aaron Leitch for your friendship and for giving the manuscript a pre-read. Thank you to Mar Thomas, *Primate for the United States of the Apostolic Johannite Church*, for your kind words about the book. A tremendous thank you to ✠John Michael Greer for taking time out of a harrowing writing schedule to read the piece and inspiring me to keep writing. Thank you to ✠Sara Greer for all of the assistance with Ordination in the *Universal Gnostic Fellowship* and allied Orders. Thank you to Archimandrite Nazarios, *Jerusalem Patriarchate*, for spiritual direction and guidance with the Prayer of the Heart. Thank you to Hieromonk Innokenty, *Orthodox Church of America*, for teaching me how to chant Vespers and instilling within me a love of the Mystical theology of the Eastern Church. Thank you to Bro Cassian of *Holy Spirit Monastery* for your friendship and "backstage pass" at the Trappist Monastery.

Thank you to my lovely wife and children for being patient with me as I wrote this text in a wave of inspiration and heat.

And lastly, thank you to Michael-Paul Bertiaux for gifting us with his unique and creative world and for his correspondence and encouragement in the Orders.

✠*Palamas*

Preface

The book you are now holding in your hands is not really a "book." Not in any conventional sense. To begin reading the words of Tau Palamas in SYZYGY is to be AUTOMATICALLY and IMMEDIATELY connected to a vast spectrum of Being typically unnoticed by the conscious mind with its pressing priorities and churning concerns. We might say this text, with its accompanying artworks, is a mutable message sent into the Heart of the Hearer. Written from WITHIN the Monastery of the Seven Rays, one must also be Present in this Mysterious and Sacred Space to partake of what is being offered.

Tau Palamas opens the doors to this divine dimension by introducing the Gyrovagi, Monks on the Move, Devotees who have not chosen to be tied to a Cloistered Life. The Monk of this Gnosis is operative in an unstable universe of perpetually shifting affairs. This entails the entirety of the World, both inner and outer, what Wittgenstein would define as "all that is the case." For the Gyrovagi, however, the "case" goes beyond the outer world identified by the senses *and* the inner world of assimilation and organization. The Devotional Center of each Monk is found in a vision complimenting and calling to the first Syzygical setup. Syzygy refers to a Divine Pairing, a Union. The Gnostic Gyrovagi has not merely imagined another world but KNOWN IT through direct contact. This does not imply perfection. Simple contact with an all-pervasive perfection but begins a process (as understood from our human standpoint) within the Heart. This Knowing forms a link between the Perfection and the sudden shifts of temporal experience which we are inclined to regard as the Imperfect or "Fallen" World. The Monk is therefore brought to the Place of Crucifixion, the Crossroads of Legbha, a Mystical and Trans-Rational Juncture which Theologian Paul Tillich sees as the birthplace of the New Being. Life and Death meet here that the Eternal and Temporal may conjoin. So many schools of religion or the occult are driven towards the "Eternal" in a direct line of "Ascent," an escape route from the "World Gone Wrong." This "Eternal," however, is emanating into the "Temporal" and it is through a Co-operative engagement that Eternity may unveil itself into Time.

Thus it is that Palamas observes an inclination of the Gyrovagi towards exposure to Hell, a "courting of instability." The word instability is not meant to imply some romantic notion of hurling oneself into self-

destructive paths. Palamas is quick to point out the importance of refilling and refreshing along the Great Way (or "Grand Chemin," as we say). It is easy to indulge in one extreme or another but the Gyrovagi struggles with the balance and union between these two (yet another Divine Pair!).

Within the Monastery Teachings, our Patriarch Michael Bertiaux observes: "The greater the tension the greater the occultist." But this tension does not imply conflict. Rather, tension can ever increase when occurring within a vehicle capable of withstanding and directing it. It is not an issue of one side triumphing over the other but of the transformation of both through the Heart of the Occultist, who is likewise transfigured.

As a clergyman, Palamas leads us through the established forms of the Church as devices for entering into the experience of Soulgrowth and Gnosis but this does not imply that the reader must follow suit by joining any church. Rather, one is invited to translate the rites, devotions and forms directly into the occult imagination. As is noted in his words, energies become ENTITIES and these Entities are instructive and empowering in their nature. Through the spiritualism dominant in the atmosphere of the Monastery, one will be led into workshops where the underlying principles of craftsmanship will culminate in a Modus Operandi unique to each student. Those principles permeate every creative form and are rooted in the connective tissue which links all things together "behind the scenes." But as Bertiaux reminds us in his lovely lessons, Occultism will only ask us to become ourselves.

Within the Monastery Teachings, one will read of Lattices and Matrices. These point toward that baseline energy surging through all of our specialized endeavors. Through diversity of form, we must work through (and even establish) these linkage points. These join our personal maps to a grand structure behind all maps.

And what is *this* joined to?

Palamas writes:

"Beyond our physical representative of the entire system (Michael-Paul Bertiaux) there are the Masters of the planes, the Saints, the Lwa, the Masters of Magick, the Aeons and cosmic Syzygies...on and on and on!!! And beyond all energies and essences of the spirits...we have the ABSOLUTE! We have no position other than a humble one to maintain within this system."

So, how does one find an entry point whereby to come into the many spaces we are speaking of?

It is to be found in this very book, in the presence of Tau Palamas as he conveys his Spirit through the medium of the written word. Although highly detailed, *Syzygy* is very "user friendly." Palamas is careful to explain

many obtuse and strange terms in plain language. His goal is not to target a select audience or to mystify the reader. Rather, he (much like Bertiaux) seeks to make truly profound and occult realities accessible for all who hunger for these truths. There is a natural and flowing beauty to this. One does not need to comprehend all the ideas presented in these pages but simply open to their atmosphere. The learning occurs on a deeper level of the contemplative mind.

With its substantial supplemental material, prayers and ceremonial in Book 2, *Syzygy* is a handbook for the Gyrovagi Spirit within yourself. Whether you choose to seek study with our Orders, enter into the Ecclesia or simply work with this material on your own, the Gates are opened here. We are grateful to Tau Palamas for his labors in bringing *Syzygy* into the world. May it serve you well as you navigate the vicissitudes of life in all of its aspects.

Kyle Fite
Sovereign Grand Master for OTOA-LCN

Introduction

"This Way is the way of the Gnosis, a very ancient word from the Greek language, which means the knowing of the spiritually attuned. In the Gnostic church, which is based upon esoteric prayer and spiritualism, we teach all persons to become attuned to the ways and words, or powerful lessons, which come from the Holy Spirits."
~Michael Bertiaux, *VGW* iii

The Monastery of the Seven Rays exists on multiple planes. It has a physical locale in the home of Michael-Paul Bertiaux in Chicago, Il USA. This will probably strike the reader as strange, but the entire world of Voudon✠Gnosis is far from the norm. What becomes even more demanding of the imagination is that the essence of the Monastery is spiritual. Its structures, cloisters…its scriptorium and workshops, Chapels and shrines are accessible through the means of the diaphanous regions which can be traversed through something akin to auto-suggestive trance states. The Monastery maintains a series of Courses that span a period of over four years. They are of such a mystical consistency that by the basic process of thoughtfully *reading* the material, some of these structures…these mental palaces, cathedrals and pieces of spiritual architecture appear in the mind's eye without so much as an invitation. Furthermore, the practices inherent in the material are initiatic in scope and often result in profound dreamwork, contact with spiritual entities and the understanding of spiritual verities and advancement upon the path of Light. From the very beginning then, we recognize that within the strata of the Western Esoteric Tradition—vast and varied as it may be—the Monastery of the Seven Rays stands apart as unique and powerful, albeit a little known or utilized system.

The above quote from our Beloved Patriarch Michael Bertiaux is a succinct statement on the nature of Gnosis and the unified field of Voudon✠Gnosis. Our title suggests this unity. There are many definitions of *syzygy,* but the original Greek word, *syzygos* means "yoked together." Another way of looking at a syzygy is to consider it a *cosmic pairing,* one form of which is discussed in the chapter, *Caritas*. Within this particular quote, Bertiaux places all under the "Gnostic Church," wherein this esoteric prayer <u>and</u> spiritualism come to life. My personal

quest and journey is Ecclesiastical in nature and so these reflections will be primarily from the standpoint of a Gnostic Clergyman. A key word in this powerful quote is *attune*, mentioned twice. Surely if this path can be summed up in a single word it is *attunement*; the very purpose of this book is the further awareness and development of *attunement* to the spiritual verities about us, our bodies and the Light we inherently possess and the manifold ways in which we encounter and work with the Holy Spirits. Each attendee of the Monastery will have a unique experience within it and will bring to it his or her own specific purpose and gnostic space.

Before proceeding further, I must admit to my being an absolute Neophyte in this arena. In fact, I am such of the *Beginner's mind* that I would suggest the monastic title of Postulant. However, the transformative and creative changes that have occurred in my life since taking my first steps across the threshold of the Monastery, via the brilliant Coursework therein, are unparalleled to **any** experiences I have had in the diverse branches of the Western Esoteric Tradition upon which I have embarked over the past thirteen years. It has been nothing less than a transmutation of both my creativity and my connection to the spirit world and I have the Monastery, Patriarch Michael-Paul Bertiaux and the vast Tradition of Voudon✠Gnosis to thank for it. As the material of the Monastery of the Seven Rays is privately utilized in Voudon✠Gnostic Orders, I will refrain from quoting directly from it and respect its lack of publication, and instead—utilize the colossal and mysterious, *Voudon Gnostic Workbook* (*VGW*) of Michael-Paul Bertiaux.

The initial core teachings on Voudon✠Gnosis came to light in the form of Coursework from the Monastery of the Seven Rays (M7Rs, for short). The monastic *feel* of the following pages is based upon this notion that if we are practicing the Coursework and Lessons, then we are effectively members, even if only virtually, of the Monastery. In the Benedictine Tradition there is an Order for individuals attached to a Monastery in this way—it is that of *Oblates*. An Oblate may live at a Monastery or Convent—yet maintain a normal work life outside of such; or—and this is more often the case—live in the world altogether, while cultivating a deep and formal relationship to a specific Monastery. It is the latter relationship that we resemble as votaries of the M7Rs. The optional *Ritual Act of Oblation* found in Book 2 is meant to serve as a powerful Formal Vow to the Spirits & Saints, to take up this life within the Mystical Monastery and to form a *contract* with these Holy Spirits for mutual assistance and enlightenment.

Monastic Life is one characterized by balance, with periods of the day marked for communal prayer, private study and meditation, manual labor